



OFF-SIDE

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TRUMP'S AMERICA: A HOST NATION LIKE NO OTHER

Trump's tariffs and travel bans **threaten** the 2026 FIFA World Cup, forcing FIFA to navigate political tensions and uncertainty over team participation and fan movement.

In Donald Trump's America, it seems, everything is up for grabs — nothing is sacred, nothing sacrosanct. The US President nurtures the unconstitutional fantasy of a third term — unbothered by the reality that the US Constitution allows a President a maximum of two stints in office. Not willing to be cloistered just in his own country, he is also determined to dismantle the global order we had grown comfortable with.

The American President recently announced April 2 as "Liberation Day," imposing a blanket 10 per cent tariff on every country. And if you're on his bad list — China with a 54 per cent penalty and India with 26 — you'll foot an even heavier bill. As other nations retaliated with reciprocal measures, global stock markets tumbled into what financial analysts describe as a complete meltdown.

Sport, too, will soon face his unpredictable touch. With two international competitions heading to the US — the 2026 FIFA World Cup and the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics — the sporting world is desperate not to offend the often-erratic leader.

The 48-team FIFA World Cup, scheduled for June and July 2026, must navigate Trump's fickle decision-making first. Gianni Infantino, the FIFA president, has already made his pilgrimage to the White House, but soon he might be asked to perform a delicate diplomatic dance to ensure that every qualified country can participate in the tournament, despite the President's ever-shifting rules about who is — and isn't — welcome on American soil.

Already qualified, Iran might miss out on a fourth consecutive World Cup appearance, as it appears on a red list of 10 countries whose citizens are set to be barred from entering the United States under the Trump administration. According to the current schedule, the only loophole seems to be placing the Asian nation as the third-seeded team in Group A (one of 12 groups of four teams each), ensuring all its group-stage matches occur

safely across the border in co-host Mexico. Iran would continue to play in Mexico until the quarterfinals, but only if it wins the group. However, it has never progressed beyond the group stage in six previous World Cup appearances.

Cuba, which is in the second round of the CONCACAF qualifiers, might face a similar conundrum if it secures one of the available slots — three direct and two inter-confederation play-off spots — to qualify for its first World Cup since 1938. It received three points from its home game in the qualifiers after Cayman Islands forfeited the match fearing potential travel risk for Cayman's players, a number of whom either study or train in the US.

The play-offs are scheduled for March 2026, and a last-minute change in fixtures, sure to throw organisers into a tizzy, can never be ruled out.

Seven years ago, when the joint bid of the United States, Canada, and Mexico was awarded the World Cup, the overriding theme was "the unity of the three nations," as articulated by Carlos Cordeiro, then-president of the US Soccer Federation. But much has changed since, and souring ties between the co-hosts and neighbours could bring challenges that FIFA had never envisaged.

"Oh, I think it's going to make it more exciting," Trump said during an Oval Office appearance with Infantino last month. "Tension's a good thing."

And tensions are indeed mounting between the three nations, as Trump provocatively talks about making Canada the 51st State and conducting an immigration crackdown at the Mexican border.

The foremost casualties of this trade and cold war might be football fans, as immigration policies and a reduction in government services in the US, under the DOGE (Department of Government Efficiency) programme, could complicate movement between the host nations.